

Alex Stoner

CPRE 4940

General Education Reflection

Although much of my coursework focuses on cybersecurity and the technical skills, knowledge, and attributes required to succeed in the field, the foundation of my degree is general education courses. At first, I didn't understand why I had to take courses that don't directly pertain to cybersecurity, but throughout my time at Iowa State, I realized I was wrong. There are personal and professional benefits to these seemingly "unrelated" courses. I have gathered a greater understanding of the world and the people in it that I will be able to bring into my future career to be a better cybersecurity engineer, coworker, and leader.

During the first semester of my freshman year, I took ECON 101: Principles of Microeconomics. The course focuses on topics such as supply and demand, the market system, and competition. I was interested in the details, specifically on the factors that drive the market and the impact they have on resources and production. These principles are important in every business and industry, and having a basic understanding provides me insights into the motivations of my future employers. Although I will be working in cybersecurity, which is oftentimes not a front-facing part of the business, it is important to know that the business side of an organization directly impacts the rest of the company. Additionally, insights into market performance provides context to protect the business, employees, and customers.

Furthermore, understanding economics will continue to help with future engineering problems. Even within cybersecurity, creating positive solutions that address the risk and security of the organization can help improve the company's profitability. Security is often thought of as a cost and expenditure for many companies without bringing money in. But ECON 101 has shown

me the competitiveness of the market and how suddenly it can change. Focusing on making decisions that benefit the security of the customer, and their data, is a reason people will choose to trust one company over another. Customers oftentimes have a scarcity of resources, and positive customer-focused security solutions will drive business profits rather than acting only as an expenditure.

Another course that I found great value in was SOC 3300: Ethnic and Race Relations. Throughout this course, we explored the history and psychology of race relations within the United States. The course contained discussions, documentaries, and articles that discussed how one's race and religion impact on the way they are treated. No matter where you go or work, you will interact with people with different backgrounds, including race, ethnicity, and religion. SOC 3300 has provided me with a broader understanding of the hardships that other people face on a day-to-day basis simply because of the color of their skin or the country they are from. Today, some of society's biggest issues are centered around race and religion. I believe one of the prominent is the struggle for people to put their differences aside and treat others with the respect and kindness they deserve. It pulls society apart and creates bigger divides between us. Without trying to understand one another, we lack empathy for another's struggles. By taking SOC 3300, I have better insight into why a person may think or act the way they do based on their culture and experiences. Using that perspective, I can be a more effective teammate, leader, and friend in both my personal and professional life. The security solutions I hope to create will be customer-focused, which requires an ability to understand the concerns or feelings of those I am trying to protect. Taking courses like SOC 3300 is necessary because it demonstrates the importance of walking through life with empathy and understanding, and the impact that it can have on those around you.

Throughout my time at Iowa State, I have had the privilege of taking courses that change the way I think and my perspective of the world. They help shape you into a well-rounded individual with a wide range of knowledge. These courses have taught me the importance of building customer-focused solutions to benefit both the customer and the business. I will continue to apply my knowledge from these general education courses to better myself in all aspects of life.